

EWCF REVEALS FORMAT, VENUE FOR ESPORTS NATIONS CUP 2026

Applications for the tournament will
remain open till January 31, 2026

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The Esports World Cup (EWC) has seen some fierce contests between individuals and clubs in the last two years of its inception.

But the true essence of World Cups is clashes between nations – something the Esports World Cup Foundation (EWCF) has now decided to introduce through the Esports Nations Cup (ENC), set to debut in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia, in November 2026.

“Nation versus nation competition is the ultimate expression of sport,” said Ralf Reichert, CEO of the Esports World Cup Foundation.

“The ENC makes this a reality for esports, giving every fan a flag to rally behind and every player the pride of representing their country.

It’s a stage to create heroes, inspire the next generation, and, together with our partners and stakeholders, build the national ecosystems that will accelerate the growth of esports worldwide.”

Applications for the tournament will remain open at esportsnationscup.com till January 31, 2026.

Each selected national team partner will nominate a manager who will serve as the public lead and primary representative of the national team.

The manager would act as the primary contact between the EWCF and the local ecosystem team, supporting coordination, representation and activation at the country and territory level, and will be formally confirmed by the EWCF.

To support the long-term growth of nation-based esports, the EWCF will establish the ENC Development

• Fund, committing at least USD 20 million annually, beginning with ENC 2026.

COMPETITION FORMAT

• The 2026 edition of ENC will feature 16 titles played over four weeks with team-based and solo-player formats.

• At the ENC Finals, team competitions will feature 24 to 48 national teams per title, while solo competitions will include 32 to 128 players.

• Each nation will be represented by one official national team per title and up to two players per title in solo competitions. In certain titles, qualification pathways may allow multiple teams or players from the same nation to compete at earlier stages to determine the official national representative.

• Half of all participating national teams and players will receive direct invitations based on the competitive performance of players from their respective countries across the esports season in each game title.

• All remaining teams will qualify through open regional online qualifiers.

• National teams will be formed as distinct line-ups, i.e. full club rosters will not be permitted as national teams. All national players and teams at the ENC’s Finals event will be guaranteed to play at least three matches.

• While national team partners will be responsible for the organisation and representation of national teams, the competitive integrity and player eligibility will remain governed by ENC rules and game partners-aligned processes.